

contain a bit of 'me' - yes, 'you'. With so many different MEs and YOUS, there are no obvious rules. [One man's garbage is another man's treasure.] It depends entirely on the collective whims and moods of the populace the meme is entering. The meme must pass unnatural selection.

Memes are information, and so are genes, however there are key differences in this similarity as well. Life's molecules store information in an objective way, in a way that is actionable by itself. DNA, mRNA, ribosomes and the rest do not require special interpreters to give them life, they are a completely self-sustaining, self-replicating and hence self-evolving system. In contrast, memes are subjective. Though memes are also stored in a physical medium, they require subjective interpretation. A meme in the form of an English sentence is instantly dead to a Jarawa tribesman, whereas the relationship of lightning to thunder is a more universal meme. Memes sustain, replicate and evolve via all the multitude of selves that perceive and then either propagate or forget them. Each single person affects every meme he/she comes across and each meme is affected by every person whose mind it reaches. If nothing else, everyone can be responsible for the memes they spread in the world. Like genes, memes evolve via changes during replication. Yet again, there is a fundamental difference - when genes evolve, their underlying physical medium changes

with the information. The medium and the message of life are coupled. Change the most insignificant amino acid in a protein's structure and the efficiency drops a thousandfold, but for memes, it is all about the information. Whether you print on paper or view on a screen, Overly Attached Girlfriend is still gonna look at you the same!



.. or from on a cake ..



**SO YOU'RE TELLING ME,
MEMES MAKES US
WHO WE ARE?**

How did this whole meme meme begin?

Before Richard Dawkins approached the concept of a meme, he began by asking an apt question about human behaviour: Why do so many of us do things that we know are bad for us? What makes us consciously counterproductive and subliminally self-defeating? How can people give up their lives willingly? Just as every river or stream has a source, every effect should have a cause. So there

must be an answer to the question, and in looking for it, what better place to start than nature herself? Indeed there are examples of non-human life forms exhibiting self-defeating behaviour that leads to them landing up dead, contrary to the innate survival instincts. For example, some mice suddenly act fearless towards cats and end up eaten. This doesn't make sense until you learn

that a parasite (*Toxoplasma gondii*) hijacks the mouse in order to make its way back into the cat's gut and complete its life cycle.

In case of us humans, to really find the cause, Dawkins decided to look at who/what was benefitting from the person's self-destructive behaviour. There was the answer - the idea!

The ideal! The meme! When a person gives up his life willingly for his country, it doesn't help the person but it surely and efficiently helps spread the meme of martyrdom. In that one sense the gene and meme similarity rings very true - both are selfishly biased to their own propagation or survival, though not consciously.

Going by the general yet useful definition of a meme as a (pseudo) unit of cultural transmission, it would seem that memes are central to making us who we are, even if we haven't identified them all. Sometimes even when we don't know the background info associated with a meme, it can still trigger the appropriate feelings and we 'get' it. Humans are social animals and that is why we transmit or communicate in the first place - it is our innate need to bond. Perhaps memes are a medium that facilitates this bonding, allowing us to give and take parts of ourselves to share with as many people as can 'get' the meme. Perhaps memes are the simplest form of art. When a meme most accurately reflects our experience of the world, we call it truth.

Memes have everything to do with meaning, they are intrinsic to the way we conscious sentient beings experience and make sense of the world. Just as life exists, and will continue to, because our environment is conducive to it, memes will continue to exist as long as humans can perceive meaning. Which gets us thinking: will memetics help us understand the psyche, consciousness and intelligence? Once all humans are in pods a la The Matrix, will the AI have its own memes? Thanks to all the memes available on the internet, it won't have any trouble simulating a satisfying world for us, that's for sure. 



Not sure if you get it ..